

SOLO HIKE NOTES

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Trails: Black Balsam Knob and Shining Rock Wilderness

Updated: January 2026

General notes on the Art Loeb Trail section through the Shining Rock Wilderness.

These are personal trail notes, not official guides. Conditions change. Always check current weather and road conditions before heading out.

BLACK BALSAM KNOB via Art Loeb Trail

Trailhead: Black Balsam Road (FS 816) off Blue Ridge Parkway, MP 420.2

Distance: 4.3 miles out and back to summit

Elevation gain: 810 feet

Difficulty: Moderate, some exposed ridgeline

Time (my pace): 2 hours 20 minutes round trip with stops

Access:

Black Balsam Road is unpaved and rough. The Outback handles it fine but go slow after rain.

Parking lot at the trailhead fills by 9 AM on weekends in fall. Arrive by 7:30 if you want quiet.

No fee, no permit required as of fall 2025.

Trail notes:

The first mile climbs steadily through beech and spruce. After the tree line opens up, the ridgeline is fully exposed. Wind picks up fast. Bring an extra layer even in summer.

The summit is a broad bald with 360-degree views. Pisgah Ridge north, Shining Rock east.

On a clear November morning the light is extraordinary.

Personal best: solo in October 2025, left at 7:45 AM, summit by 9:10, back by 10:15.

Wore the Salomon trail runners. No trekking poles needed but they help on the descent.

Gear I carry on this trail:

Salomon trail runners or Danner boots (wet weather)

Rain shell, always, even if clear at trailhead

Two liters water

Headlamp (habit from early starts)

Small first aid kit

Phone charged to 100, downloaded offline map

Bugs and wildlife:

Black bears are active in this area. Made noise on trail, saw no bears.

Saw a peregrine falcon on the November 2025 hike, low and close, probably hunting.

Yellow jackets bad in September near the parking area.

SHINING ROCK via Art Loeb Trail

Trailhead: Ivestor Gap or Daniel Boone Scout Camp (longer approach)

Distance: 8.2 miles out and back from Ivestor Gap

Elevation gain: 1,200 feet

Difficulty: Moderate to strenuous, long day

Time (my pace): 4 hours 30 minutes with stops

The quartz outcrops are extraordinary. Shining Rock is named for them correctly.

On a clear day the white rock glows. I have done this in August heat and in fall cold and the fall cold wins. Bring more water than you think you need in summer.

Parking at Ivestor Gap requires the Blue Ridge Parkway to be open. Check status before driving.

This trail is longer and more serious than Black Balsam. Not for a short window of time.

I prefer a 6 AM start to be back by early afternoon.